



# Embers of the Forsaken Keep

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Author Name





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|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
|    | Aisen — bastard master        |   | Caspian — reluctant monster |
|    | Corvin — hollow knight        |   | Ryo — lightning prodigy     |
|    | Kael — loyal outcast          |   | Kairos — trapped looper     |
|   | Orin — hollow wanderer        |  | Amara — burdened keeper     |
|  | Renard — fourth-party witness |                                                                                    |                             |

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## The Weight of Ash & Embers

The wind came down from the Grey Mountains carrying the smell of burnt cedar and something older — something that had no name in the common tongue, but which every soldier recognised in the hollow of their ribs. Aisen tightened the strap of his vambrace and said nothing.

Below, the valley curved like a wound in the earth, its floor dark with the remnants of what had been three villages not a fortnight past. The smoke still rose in thin, patient threads, as though the ground itself had not yet decided whether to forgive.

*“We should not have come this way,”* said the boy behind him. He did not turn. The boy said many true things. That was what made him dangerous to keep near and impossible to send away.

. . .

He counted the fires. Seven. No — eight, if the far glow past the treeline was theirs and not some shepherd’s accident. Eight fires meant a column, not a raid. A column meant orders. Orders meant someone, somewhere, had decided this particular valley was worth the cost of making it into a memory.



Aisen had spent seventeen years learning the difference between decisions made in rooms and decisions that lived in the soil afterward. He had yet to find a word for the distance between them.

The boy's name was Edric. He was sixteen, which meant he had never known a year without the war, and also meant he was precisely old enough to believe that this was a fact worth mourning. Aisen had stopped mourning facts some time around his thirtieth season. There were too many of them, and the mourning cost the same whether or not you could change the thing you were mourning.

. . .

*"How many do you count?" he asked.*

Edric shifted behind him. *"Eight. Unless the far one is a shepherd."*

*"It isn't."*

*"How do you know?"*

*"Shepherds don't build fires at the treeline." He finally turned. "They build them where the animals are."*

Edric looked at the fire. He was going to ask something else — Aisen could see it taking shape in the set of his jaw — and then he decided not to, which meant he had already guessed the answer. He was almost proud of him for that.



## Notes for the author

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**Switching POV** — At the top of each chapter file (or each section), set:

```
\renewcommand{\ActiveCharacter}{Caspian}
```

Valid names: Aisen, Caspian, Corvin, Ryo, Kael, Kairos, Orin, Amara, Renard.

Both the corner glyph and the stripe colour update automatically.

**Chapter stripe** — Change `\CurrentChapterNum` (integer) and `\CurrentChapterLabel` (label string). `\TotalChapters` is set to 52; change it once if your final count differs. The block position recalculates itself.

**Scene location** — Change `\SceneLocation` for the small-caps label under the horizon line. The silhouette itself stays the same; to swap it, edit the three `\fill` paths in `\HeaderStrip` (far mountains, mid mountains, treeline).

**Scene break** — `\SceneBreak` inserts three centred midpoints.

**Dialogue** — `{\color{Stone}\itshape ``...''}`

**Drop cap** — `\lettrine[lines=3]{T}{he rest}` at the start of a chapter.

**Compile** — `xelatex` twice. First pass writes TikZ overlay coordinates; second pass reads them.